

Adjective order

Teaching guide

Describe an object naturally without overloading the sentence.

Understand the distinction

When several adjectives come before a noun, English tends to put opinion before more factual descriptions. A useful common order is opinion, size, age, shape, color, origin, material, purpose, then noun.

This is a tendency, not a requirement to use every category. Meaning, emphasis, and established phrases can affect order. Two or three well-chosen adjectives are usually clearer than a long stack. Use a dictionary or a natural example if an order feels uncertain.

Compare the patterns

OPINION + SIZE

a lovely small cafe

An opinion comes before size.

AGE + MATERIAL

an old wooden chair

Age comes before material.

COLOR + ORIGIN

a blue Italian jacket

Color normally comes before origin.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the natural order: bag / leather / small / a

- A. small a leather bag
- B. a small leather bag
- C. a leather small bag

2. Choose the natural order: wooden / old / an / table

- A. an old wooden table
- B. an wooden old table
- C. old an wooden table

3. Must every description include all adjective categories?

- A. No. Choose only useful details.
- B. No. You can only use one adjective for an object.
- C. Yes. Each object needs every adjective category.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. The notebook is small and blue. Which description has the natural neutral order?

- A. I keep my notes in small a blue notebook.
- B. I keep my notes in a large red notebook.
- C. I keep my notes in a small blue notebook.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. B. a small leather bag

Size normally comes before material.

A: The article a normally comes before these adjectives.

C: Size normally comes before material in this neutral description.

2. A. an old wooden table

Age normally comes before material.

B: Age normally comes before material, and an does not fit before wooden.

C: The article comes first: an old wooden table.

3. A. No. Choose only useful details.

The order is guidance for the adjectives you need.

B: Two or more useful adjectives can be natural.

C: Descriptions need useful information, not every possible category.

4. C. I keep my notes in a small blue notebook.

Size normally comes before color in this description.

A: The article a comes before the adjectives.

B: This changes the stated size and color.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-10.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

The notebook is small and blue. Which description has the natural neutral order?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.